it. But this time it was a slow numbing process that made me wonder if it was worth the fight. I knew I was giving up, and I was preparing myself to the eventuality. I still did not know the means to my end.

'You have decided, eh?' Geetha was shouting now. 'What happened to my strong-willed Appa? I thought you will fight and prove to the world your innocence, show the world what you are, expose the people behind this conspiracy. If not any of that, just answer this. Do you want us to live as a traitor's children? Do you want your grandchildren and the coming generations to live with such a tag?'

When I lifted my face to look at Geetha, I realised that my eyes had welled up.

'I am sorry,' I said. 'I will live to ensure that.'

The last couple of months, starting with my arrest, flashed back in my mind. I had endured enough, I resolved, never again should I let myself give up in this fight. I have to prove my innocence and expose whoever is the perpetrator.

In the coming months, the CBI officers summoned me a few times to their offices in Trivandrum and Kochi. I dutifully answered more questions from them. After a couple of visits, it became clearer to me that the CBI was convinced that I was innocent. Many of their questions, I thought, were part of running multiple checks on what I had said earlier. If the CBI had to demolish the IB spy story, they had to be doubly sure of what they are going to say.

I felt a strange sense of gratitude towards the CBI. This would, however, soon be followed by a gripping rage on the IB officials. I would pause at the thought of the IB interrogation, rewind it again, ponder over my pain and resolve to teach those conspirators a lesson.

Among the accused, we three men were to sign a register at the CJM court in Ernakulam; the two Maldivian women were still in prison after the government cited new cases of national security against them. When it would be that day of the week for us to sign at the CJM court, Sasi would dutifully come to pick me up and drive to Ernakulam every week. During the journey he would repeat the tales of torture he underwent at the hands of